

Aquatic animal diseases pose a threat to aquatic animal production and environments. Aquatic emergency animal disease threats are often difficult to predict and manage. This is because aquatic animal diseases:

- are often highly pathogenic
- have the potential to affect both wild and captive populations.

Emergency response

Aquatic animal disease incidents do occur within Australia. When a disease incident occurs, Australia's response arrangements may be activated to minimise their potential impacts on aquaculture, fisheries resources or the environment.

To report concerns of potential aquatic emergency animal disease events contact the [Emergency Animal Disease Hotline](#) on 1800 675 888.

The Aquatic Consultative Committee on Emergency Animal Disease (Aquatic CCEAD) coordinates Australia's national technical response to emergency aquatic animal disease events. It is responsible for determining the nature, extent and significance of a suspected disease event in aquatic animals in Australia.

For further information on the Aquatic CCEAD, and other committees with responsibilities for aquatic animal health in Australia, refer to the [Public policy coordination for aquatic animal health in Australia](#) webpage.

AQUAVETPLAN is a series of manuals that outline Australia's approach to national disease preparedness and proposes the technical response and control strategies to be activated in a national aquatic animal disease emergency.

AQUAVETPLAN comprises disease strategy manuals, operational procedure manuals, and management manuals. All [manuals are available to view and download on the department's website](#).

The field guide aims to help people recognise diseases of significance to aquaculture, fisheries and native fauna in Australia. The 5th edition of the guide covers 53 aquatic animal diseases of significance to Australia that affect species of finfish, crustaceans, molluscs and amphibians. The [field guide is available to view and download on the department's website](#). It is also available as a free mobile app.

The 'Outbreak!' guidelines were developed through AQUAPLAN 2022–2027, to use in the event of a disease outbreak in aquatic animals including finfish, molluscs and crustaceans. The guidelines break down the outbreak investigation process into 10 basic steps, but these steps do not necessarily need to be completed in sequence. The guidelines and their associated e-learning are available to view and download on the [Agriculture Victoria website](#).

Aquatic animal disease incidents

For information on all current responses to exotic animal and plant pest and disease (including aquatic animal disease) outbreaks nationally, refer to the [Outbreak website](#).

Emergency preparedness

Preparedness is essential for an emergency response to be effective. Australia has contingency planning arrangements in place for aquatic animal disease outbreaks, including the AQUAVETPLAN manuals outlined above.

The national priority aquatic animal disease list includes the highest priority exotic aquatic animal diseases for industry and governments to target preparedness and risk mitigation activities through biosecurity action plans.

See the [national priority aquatic animal disease list webpage](#) for further information.

There is an ongoing need to test contingency arrangements for priority diseases to ensure that they remain fit-for-purpose. Testing is achieved through exercises based on possible outbreak scenarios. For information on planned and previous aquatic animal disease simulation exercises refer to the [national simulation exercises](#) webpage.

Governments and industry share responsibilities for managing the risks associated with the spread of aquatic animal diseases. Multiple guidelines are available to help industry and governments effectively manage these risks, including guidelines for the development of on-farm biosecurity plans, the translocation of live aquatic animals and the translocation of bait and berley products.

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